

GRASSLANDS

Little shelter, but plenty of food

Where the climate is too dry to support trees, but wet enough for plants to grow, grasses and low-growing herbs dominate the landscape. These plants are highly diverse, and grassland habitats range from the high alpine meadows of Europe to tree-studded African savanna, tall grass prairies of North America, windswept Asian steppes, seas of head-height grass in India, China, and South America, and the dry desert scrublands of Australia. Today, they account for about 40 percent of the land area.

Temperate grasslands

The relatively flat terrain and scarcity of trees in temperate grassland gives rise to vast expanses of fairly uniform landscape across which strong winds can blow unimpeded. There are fewer habitats than in forests and, as a result, there are fewer animal species in temperate grassland, too. Grass is, however, able to support vast numbers of herbivores because, unusually in plants, its growth point is below ground level. As it is untouched

by the animals that graze on it, grass regrows quickly after it has been cropped. This adaptation also allows grass to survive long periods without rain that kill many other plants.

In the past, grassland covered large tracts of the temperate world, but with the advent of agriculture, much of it has been used for growing crops—often with unforeseen consequences. Grass is unusual in that it channels most of its energy into growing roots rather than leaves. This allows grass to get the water and nutrients it needs and has



TEMPERATE GRASSLAND

Although grasses predominate, many herbaceous plants also grow in temperate grassland. Bright flowers attract insects, which in turn attract insect-eating birds. The grassland also provides food for mammals of all sizes, from bison to hares.



MONTANE GRASSLAND

These high-altitude grasslands occur at all latitudes. The plants and animals that live in these regions must be able to endure low temperatures, intense sunlight, and potentially harmful ultraviolet radiation. They include the guanaco of South America.

CUSTER STATE PARK ▸

The prairie habitat in South Dakota, provides a natural refuge for a herd of American bison.

